

Lab 8 Problem Brief: Acies AgenticBus — Product Lifecycle and Portfolio Intelligence

Program: Acies Virtual Labs Build Program | Wave 1
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1. Your Lab Assignment

Your team is responsible for designing and building the **Product Lifecycle and Portfolio Intelligence** — one of eight Acies AgenticBus Virtual Labs.

Field	Detail
Lab name	Acies AgenticBus: Product Lifecycle and Portfolio Intelligence
Domain	Product Management / Portfolio Strategy
Primary VP persona	VP Product Management / VP Portfolio Strategy
Secondary personas	Product Manager, Portfolio Analyst, Pricing and Margin Partner

Read this brief alongside the **Master Program Guidance Document** and the **Build Specification Template**. The guidance document explains the SPS process and common shell rules. This brief gives you your specific problem statement, scope, and starting direction.

2. The Business Problem

2.1 Opening Problem Statement

Product and portfolio leaders struggle with slow launch decisions, poor visibility into product profitability, missed rationalization opportunities, and disconnected market and customer signals.

This is your **starting point**, not your conclusion. Your SPS work should test, refine, and validate this statement through stakeholder interviews and research before you design your solution.

2.2 Why This Problem Matters

The functional leaders in this domain face a common pattern:

- Data about what is happening is scattered across multiple systems
- Decisions are made later than they need to be, often based on stale or incomplete information
- Teams spend time on manual processes and workarounds instead of value-adding work
- When things go wrong, they are reactive rather than proactive

The virtual lab should make this pattern visible and show what it looks like when AI and agentic orchestration change it.

3. Scope

3.1 In Scope

- Portfolio health and performance by lifecycle stage
- Launch readiness assessment across market, supply, and channel dimensions
- Product and SKU profitability analysis
- SKU rationalization recommendation and simulation
- Market, competitor, and Voice-of-Customer (VoC) signal monitoring
- Portfolio and product KPIs

3.2 Out of Scope

- Full PLM (Product Lifecycle Management) engineering system
 - CAD, R&D, and technical product development workflows
 - Marketing campaign execution for launches (Lab 1)
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4. Suggested Interactive Tabs (Starting Point)

These five tabs are the **recommended starting point** for your lab's interactive modules. You may refine the names and content through your SPS work — but keep to exactly 5 domain tabs.

Tab #	Suggested name	What it should show
1	Portfolio Health Map	Product and SKU performance by lifecycle stage, margin, growth, and strategic fit
2	Launch Readiness Dashboard	Market, supply chain, channel, and pricing readiness for upcoming product launches
3	Profitability Tree	Revenue, margin, and cost-to-serve breakdown by product with leakage and complexity drivers
4	SKU Rationalisation Simulator	AI-recommended retain, grow, bundle, reposition, or sunset decisions with projected impact
5	Market and VoC Signal Board	Customer sentiment, competitor moves, demand trends, and channel signals affecting the portfolio

5. Key Performance Indicators

The lab should surface these KPIs meaningfully across its modules. Each KPI should appear in at least one tab with a realistic simulated value.

- Product / SKU margin
 - Time-to-market
 - Launch success rate (% hitting targets at 6 months)
 - SKU productivity (revenue per active SKU)
 - Portfolio complexity index
 - Cannibalization rate
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6. Role Lenses

Your lab should support these functional roles. When a user selects a role, the guided tour path, tooltip emphasis, and default tab should adapt.

Role	Who they are	What they care most about in this lab
VP Product Management	Senior functional leader	Strategic KPIs, exception escalations, key decisions
Product Manager	Domain practitioner	Operational workflows, root causes, queue management
Pricing and Margin Partner	Analyst / ops support	Data quality, process detail, reporting and analysis

7. "How This Evolves" Side Panel — Suggested Agents

Your lab's "How This Evolves" side panel should include an agent roster. Here is a suggested starting set — refine through your research.

Agent name	Suggested role
Portfolio Agent	Monitors product performance by lifecycle stage and flags underperformers
Market Signal Agent	Tracks customer sentiment, competitor actions, and demand shifts
Launch Agent	Assesses launch readiness and identifies risk factors before go-live
Profitability Agent	Explains margin drivers and cost-to-serve by product or category
Sunset Agent	Recommends rationalization candidates based on complexity, margin, and strategic fit

8. Self-Assessment Scorecard — Suggested Questions

These are your suggested scorecard questions. Refine them based on stakeholder interviews and research — the questions should reflect real pain points VPs in this domain actually feel.

1. Can you see product and SKU performance by lifecycle stage in one view?
 2. Do you know which SKUs add portfolio complexity without proportional value?
 3. Are launch decisions supported by real-time market and readiness signals?
 4. Can you predict product cannibalization before a new launch?
 5. Is product profitability visible at SKU level, including cost-to-serve?
 6. Are VoC and competitor signals systematically connected to portfolio decisions?
 7. How quickly can you identify which products to rationalize when cost pressure rises?
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9. Research Starting Points

Use these to begin your secondary research. Go beyond these — they are starting points, not a complete list.

- Research product portfolio management frameworks — McKinsey, BCG, HBR
 - Look into how leading FMCG and tech companies approach SKU rationalization
 - Explore launch readiness frameworks and why new products fail
 - Find benchmarks for time-to-market and launch success rates by industry
 - Research how AI is being applied to product portfolio decisions and pricing
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10. Key Questions Your SPS Should Answer

By the end of your Step 1 SPS presentation, you should have clear, evidence-backed answers to:

1. What is the specific root cause of the problem in this domain? (Use your diagnostic issue tree)
2. Who feels the pain most acutely — the VP or the practitioner? How is it different for each?
3. Which of the suggested tabs delivers the most business value, and why?
4. What data does this lab need to demonstrate the problem and the solution convincingly?
5. What does the "Now vs AI-Assisted vs Agentic" evolution look like specifically in this domain?
6. What would a 10x improvement in this function look like, and what enables it?

11. Common Pitfalls for This Lab

- Focusing on the technology (agents, AI) before clearly articulating the business problem
- Making the AgenticBus the hero instead of the functional modules
- Using vague or unmeasurable KPIs (e.g., "improved efficiency") instead of specific metrics
- Designing for a generic "operations user" instead of the specific VP and practitioner roles
- Forgetting that a VP will spend 10–15 minutes with this lab — every tab must earn its place

End of Lab 8 Problem Brief